

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

MORE THAN EQUAL

Union minister of road transport and highways **Nitin Gadkari** has won praise from both sides of the political divide, even in Parliament. Now, plaudits come from someone who isn't too big a fan of the Narendra Modi government. In an interview with a YouTuber recently, economist and former RBI governor **Raghuram Rajan** said that Gadkari had done wonders in his job. The minister, Rajan said, obviously knows how to push his staff to deliver and that he was one of the most open among his colleagues in the cabinet. "I think we need more such ministers," Rajan went on to add, saying that what the country needs is "a band of equals" in the cabinet who can take the country forward.



A LOYAL IGNORE

The joke in Maharashtra BJP circles is that in its pursuit of a 'Congress-*mukt* Bharat', the party is turning into a 'Congress-*yukt* BJP', considering the number of Congress leaders who have crossed over and gotten to enjoy the perks of power. The heartburn among loyalists is evident. One of them—Chinmay Bhandari, son of senior BJP leader **Madhav Bhandari**—recently took to X to say how his father had been repeatedly overlooked for positions in the legislature and the Rajya Sabha despite his five-decade-long service to the party. Loyalty, it seems, is not enough to earn you a reward in the BJP.

GOD-FARING FOLK

Temple runs are becoming frequent in Gujarat as the Lok Sabha election closes in. Amid the ongoing state budget session, February 15 was declared a holiday as Speaker Shankar Chaudhary took 156 BJP MLAs to the Ambaji temple in Banaskantha district. At the event, covered live by the regional media, the young minister for home, **Harsh Sanghavi**, caught the attention of the cameras as he displayed his dexterity with the *shankhnaad*, dhol, manjira, and even a harmonium. Now, we hear, another trip is planned once the assembly session is over. No guesses on the destination—the Ram temple in Ayodhya, where Sanghavi will get to test his skills again.



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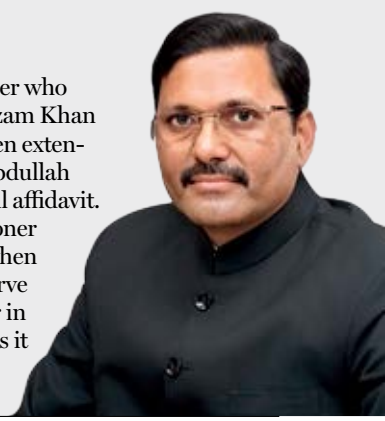
An Old Habit



NCP leader and Maharashtra deputy CM **Ajit Pawar** may have broken up with 'secular' ally Congress and tied up with the BJP, but old habits, it seems, die hard. A convention of the NCP's minority cell initially approved a resolution seeking reservations for Muslims in education, jobs and even politics. However, the critical reference to political quotas was withdrawn later after a brouhaha.

Performance Incentive

The deputation period of **Anjaneya Kumar Singh**, the IAS officer who sent Samajwadi Party (SP) leader and former Rampur MP Azam Khan to jail on charges of hate speech in the 2019 poll campaign, has been extended by another six months. Singh had also got Azam's MLA son Abdullah disqualified after an inquiry found he had fudged his age in the poll affidavit. The 2005-batch Sikkim cadre IAS officer, currently the commissioner of Moradabad, came to Uttar Pradesh (he is from Mau) in 2016, when the SP was in power. Deputation rules say an IAS officer cannot serve in another state for more than five years. Singh is in his eighth year in UP. So, someone in Lucknow is obviously looking out for him. Or is it reward for putting the Rampur strongman behind bars?



Kaushik Deka with Avishek Ghosh Dastidar, Dhaval S. Kulkarni, Jumana Shah and Ashish Misra